meltdown, even when chasing very moderate totals. Ja, those big games do amazing things to people – they blow their minds completely.

Obviously I can't discuss my BMT without mentioning the elephant in the room. The Proteas don't exactly have a reputation as a team with big-match temperament, do they? We've fallen agonisingly short at the World Cups, due mainly to an alarming degree of brain fade at critical moments. And while my batting record at these tournaments has been great, I have to include myself among the faders with my 'dropped catch' in the Super Eight stage of the 1999 World Cup against Australia. But more about that later.

In the 2007 World Cup semi-final, once more against Australia, we were again a team in meltdown mode. Our game plan had been to attack, but it was unbelievable to witness what happened instead in our innings. 'Attack' became more like 'panic', and in no time at all we were four or five wickets down. There were some really strange and totally out-of-character shots being played out there. By the time I came in to bat, the game was virtually dead.

I had listened to some of our bowlers talk before the game, and they seemed genuinely intimidated by the prospect of bowling to Matthew Hayden and Adam Gilchrist. I could see that they were shitting themselves, and I was thinking, 'Come on, okes! Surely you are up for it?'

Perhaps I should've said something and tried to be more supportive, but generally I'm not really outspoken in team talks. I don't really say how I feel about things. Yes, I think I've gained enough experience to comment in team meetings, but, to be frank, I have never played a leadership role in a team. Even when I was at school, I left the big decisions to someone else. I still wouldn't want a leadership job in any team. Some guys, though, are happy to be the captain any time. I think Graeme Smith was born to lead. Perhaps the fact that my comments are not taken seriously is part of the reason why I don't speak up. Whenever I've made a suggestion on the field, it's been declined.

Sounds like I'm avoiding the topic here, doesn't it? So … do the Proteas have BMT or not? Well, put it this way – we have a lot of talented players – always have had – but there seems to be a missing factor. If we could pin-point what that was, we would have won at least one World Cup so far.

A similar pattern repeated itself when the Cape Cobras played in the inaugural 2009 Champions League semi-final against Trinidad and Tobago